

Do all the roads lead to *Rome*?

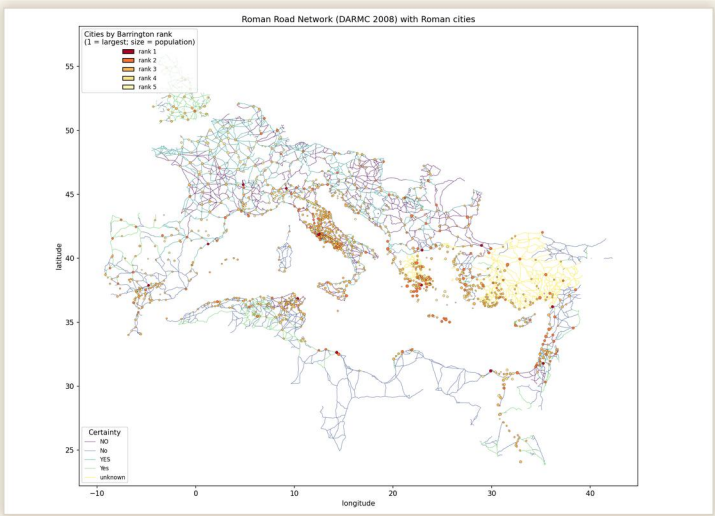
A network analysis of the Roman road system and its 1,388 cities — measuring the imperial grid, tracing which ancient cities still live on as today's metropolises, and recovering who first founded each of them.

AIM

- 1 The network.** Rebuild the DARMC Roman road network as a graph — 5,086 junctions and 7,048 segments — and measure its true hubs, corridors and bottlenecks with degree and kilometre-weighted betweenness, testing whether all roads really led to Rome.
- 2 The inheritance.** Follow Roman urbanism into the present: match each ancient city to its living successor and show how the imperial network still shapes the geography of modern Europe and the Mediterranean — London, Paris, Milan, Istanbul.
- 3 The founders.** Reveal who first settled each city — the tribes (Dorian, Ionian, Etruscan, Phoenician ...) and the persons (Romulus and Remus, Philip II, Seleucus I Nicator ...) behind the names on the map.

AT A GLANCE

5,086 / 7,048 road junctions / segments	1,388 Roman cities (100 BC–AD 300)
80% of cities within 5 km of a road	46 living successors of 300,000+
887 cities with population estimates	11 / 47 capitals ×2 (imperial / +provincial)



The road network with cities coloured by Barrington Atlas rank (dark red = Rome-scale; pale = minor).

FINDINGS

- Via** Rome's hexagon ranks #1 on both degree and kilometre-weighted betweenness — the data confirms the proverb.
- Via** Corridor capitals (Byzantium, Sirmium, Ravenna) carry the through-traffic, while terminal capitals (Rome, York, Carthage) carry almost none — betweenness measures position, not importance.
- Via** The empire's hubs are still its heirs: Londinium–London, Lutetia–Paris, Byzantium–Istanbul, Mediolanum–Milan.